



Minnehaha United Methodist Church

A Reconciling Congregation
We Love You Just the Way You Are

Welcome Friends!

We welcome you to worship wherever you may be in your faith's journey. We strive to live in the way of Jesus Christ, sharing God's love on a daily basis regardless of race, sexual orientation or faith history.

We livestream our worship services, and you may end up in view of the camera at any point in the service.

Worship Personnel

Rev. Becky Sechrist, *Pastor*;
Rev. Jean Elliott,
Director of Children, Youth, & Their Families;
Alex Rack, *Choir Director*;
Anders Nelson, *Organist*;
Tim Siefkes, *Contemporary Band Leader*;
Nicholas and Patience Sabah,
Communion Stewards

Sign in

We are delighted you are here! We invite you to "sign the welcome pad" electronically.



If you point your camera phone at the QR code below, it will take you to a google form where you can enter your information.

Giving

For our offering, you can also give electronically through the PayPal account online, or by using this QR Code (which takes you to our PayPal account).



Children in Worship

We always welcome children in worship, and we assume that they may make noise, wriggle, and even run around. If you would like childcare during worship, we do have care for children 0-4 from 9-10 a.m. on our 2nd floor. The ushers can direct you, if you would like help finding the room. In addition, we have activity bags for children at the back of the sanctuary, and we also have rocking chairs at the back for nursing or rocking a baby. Rocking chairs are also available across from the nursery on the 2nd floor.

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February 22, 2023 6:30 p.m.

Reflective Reading:

(from *Soul Feast*, by Marjorie J. Thompson)

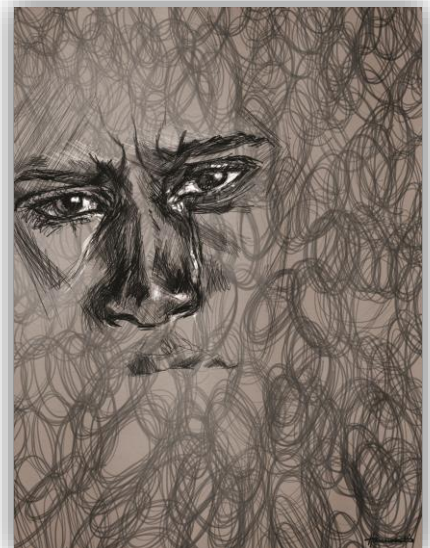
There is a hunger abroad in our time, haunting lives and hearts. Like an empty stomach aching beneath the sleek coat of a seemingly well-fed creature, it reveals that something is missing from the diet of our largely rational, secular, and affluent culture. If we look at the underbelly of this sleek creature, we notice ragged, unkempt fur and signs of disease. Even in communities that hold sacred values, much is awry. Both within and beyond traditional faith communities, a hunger for spiritual depth and integrity has been gaining momentum for several generations.

For some of us, the hunger is amorphous. Like free-floating anxiety, it lurks just below the surface of consciousness. Perhaps we feel an emptiness that leaves us restless for a larger meaning and purpose in life. Perhaps we sense that we are sailing through life in a rudderless ship. Something is missing. Something is out of balance. But it remains nameless.

For others of us, the hunger is recognizably spiritual. We know there is a vacuum inside us that will suck up an infinite supply of thrills, goods, and successes without satisfying the human heart. We are aware of needing a transcendent compass. Suffering has opened us to questions for which there are no easy answers – perhaps no answers at all. We have come to believe that only a power transcending this life can give meaning to our choices and circumstance.

Human beings are innately religious. We harbor a bedrock desire for a transcendent wellspring of meaning and purpose in life. While sociologists may attribute the universal human religious impulse to psychosocial need, people of faith believe that we are *made* for relationship with God. Therefore until that relationship is sought and found, there will always be an existential emptiness at the core of our being. Centuries ago St. Augustine confessed to God, "You have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you."

Surely God is the primary factor behind the spiritual seeking of our time. It seems the Holy Spirit stirs things up when our societies and sacred institutions get complacent, corrupt, or simply fall too far behind the evolving knowledge and ethos of the times. I believe God's intentions are the most crucial force behind the sustained tide of spiritual hunger today. Without the fidelity of divine purpose, all we can hope for when the wave of hunger has crested is the frothy aftermath of a fad. But with the integrity of divine purpose, we can trust that a truer and more authentic spirituality may emerge from our restless search for soul sustenance.



Prelude

Vesper Voluntary #5

Edward Elgar (1890)

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Call to Worship

(adapted from Sarah (Are) Speed, A Sanctified Art LLC, sanctifiedart.org)

Leader: This day

People: **is the start of something new.**

Leader: This day

People: **marks the beginning of a season.**

Leader: This day

People: **reminds us who we are.**

Leader: This day

People: **reminds us who we long to be.**

Leader: So on this day,

People: **let us worship God.**

Hymn

The Faith We Sing

Sunday's Palms Are Wednesday's Ashes #2138

Rae E. Whitney © 1991 Selach Publishing Co., Inc.

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Prayers *(with a time for silent reflection after each)*

Let us pray for those around the world without adequate food, shelter, clothing, or health care ...

Let us pray for those near to us; our families, friends, members of our congregations

Let us pray for all the ways in which we have impeded another person's connection to God

Let us pray for our own hearts, minds, bodies, souls

Let us pray for leaders of our own nation and leaders of nations around the world

Let us pray for the church in all of its various forms

Let us pray for all that God has created – the earth, the animals, and all that creation has brought forth . . .

Reading

Joel 2:1-2, 12-17

Anthem

Chancel Choir

Create in Me

Michael Larkin

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Sermon

“Where is God?”

Imposition of Ashes

Quinquagesime

Dom Paul Benoit, OSB

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Hymn

The United Methodist Hymnal

There's a Wideness in God's Mercy #121

Frederick W. Faber Harm. © 1989 The United Methodist Publishing House.

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Postlude

Largo

G.F. Handel, arr. Hal Hopson

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